Sacrifice and the Day of Atonement

Leviticus 1–7; 16; Hebrews 9–10

The big idea: Sin brings death, and a holy God in mercy accepts a substitute: a life for a life. Every sacrifice in Leviticus, and the high priest behind the veil on the Day of Atonement, points to Jesus, the priest who sat down because his single sacrifice was finished.

Before you meet: Read

Leviticus 1:1–9 | Leviticus 16:1–22 | Leviticus 16:29–34 | Hebrews 9:11–14 | Hebrews 10:11–18

Open (5 minutes)

Have you ever tried to make up for something you did wrong? How did you know when you had done enough?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"For the life of the flesh is in the _____, and I have given it for you on the altar to make _____ for your souls." *(Leviticus 17:11)*

"He shall lay his _____ on the head of the burnt offering, and it shall be accepted for him to make atonement for him." *(Leviticus 1:4)*

"You shall be _____, for I the LORD your God am holy." *(Leviticus 19:2)*

"Aaron shall lay both his hands on the head of the live goat, and _____ over it all the iniquities of the people of Israel." *(Leviticus 16:21)*

"You shall be _____ before the LORD from all your sins." *(Leviticus 16:30)*

Christ "entered once for all into the holy places, not by means of the blood of goats and calves but by means of his own _____, thus securing an _____ redemption." *(Hebrews 9:12)*

Discuss

1. What was your first reaction to all the blood in Leviticus? How does a life for a life change the way you see it? *Leviticus 17:11; Romans 6:23*

2. The worshiper laid his hand on the animal and then killed it himself. Why do you think God designed it that way? *Leviticus 1:3–5*

3. Why did God take the sin of Nadab and Abihu so seriously? What does it teach about coming to God on our own terms? *Leviticus 10:1–3*

4. The two goats show sin paid for and sin carried away. Which of those do you most need to believe today? *Leviticus 16:15–22; Psalm 103:12*

5. If "it is impossible for the blood of bulls and goats to take away sins," how were believers in Israel forgiven? How is their faith like yours? *Hebrews 10:4; Leviticus 4:31*

6. Every priest stood daily, but Christ sat down. What would change in your life if you really believed nothing is left to pay? *Hebrews 10:11–14, 18*

Apply this week

Read Leviticus 16 slowly, then Hebrews 10:11–18. Aaron confessed Israel's sins by name over the goat. This week, name your sins to God one by one, then thank him that Christ has carried them away. If there is a sin you keep trying to pay for, read Hebrews 10:18 aloud: "there is no longer any offering for sin."

Memory verse

"But when Christ had offered for all time a single sacrifice for sins, he sat down at the right hand of God."

Hebrews 10:12

Pray

Thank God that he is holy and that he provided a way for sinners to come near. Thank Jesus for taking your place, bearing God's anger against your sin, and carrying your guilt away. Ask for faith to rest in his finished work and a heart that turns from sin.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 11

Sacrifice and the Day of Atonement

Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Leviticus 16:1–22 aloud, then Hebrews 10:11–18.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 2, 4, and 6 matter most.
5 min	Walk the group through the Day of Atonement diagram in the full lesson: the bull, the goat for the LORD, and the goat sent away.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 12 (Numbers 13–14, Deuteronomy 6, and Joshua 1).

Main points to land

1. Sin is rebellion against the source of life, and its wages is death. In mercy God accepted a substitute: the laid-on hand meant this animal stands in my place (Leviticus 1:4; 17:11).
2. The five offerings cover all of life with God: guilt removed, devotion given, thanks offered, and fellowship enjoyed. The peace offering ended at a table, because the goal of atonement is fellowship with God.
3. God is holy, and no one may come before him on his own terms (Leviticus 10:1–3; 19:2). His holiness also shapes ordinary life: love your neighbor as yourself (Leviticus 19:18).
4. On the Day of Atonement the blood of one goat covered the broken law in God's presence, and the other goat carried the people's sins away. Sin paid for and sin removed, but only for one year at a time (Leviticus 16:15–22, 34).
5. Jesus is both priest and sacrifice. He bore God's just anger as our propitiation and carried our sins away, once for all, then sat down. Faith receives this gift, and repentance always comes with it (Romans 3:25–26; Hebrews 10:12, 18).

Answer key (Observe)

1. blood; atonement
2. hand
3. holy
4. confess
5. clean
6. blood; eternal

Questions people will ask

Why would God want animals killed? And did those sacrifices actually work?
Sacrifice showed in blood what sin costs and that God would accept a substitute. Hebrews says animal blood could never take away sins (10:4), yet Leviticus says the worshiper was forgiven (4:31). Both are true: believing Israelites were forgiven by faith in the promised Messiah, the sacrifices being God's signs pointing to Christ (WCF 7.5; 8.6). Now that he has come, no more sacrifices are needed.

Why did God kill Nadab and Abihu? What was unauthorized fire?
We do not know exactly. The text stresses that they offered fire the LORD had not commanded (10:1). Some point to the ban on priests drinking that follows (10:8–9), but the text does not say. The lesson is in verse 3: God will be treated as holy. The wonder is not that two died, but that God makes a way for any sinner to come near.

What or who is Azazel?
The meaning of the Hebrew word is debated. It may mean the goat that goes away (Tyndale's scapegoat), a remote and desolate place, or a name for a wilderness demon. It was never a payment to the devil: both goats were presented before the LORD (16:7, 10). The picture is clear whatever the word means. The sins are carried away and do not come back.

If Jesus' sacrifice is finished, what are we doing at the Lord's Supper?
We are not offering Christ again; his sacrifice was once for all (Hebrews 10:12, 18). Nor is it only a memory exercise. By faith believers truly feed on Christ and receive the benefits of his death for their spiritual nourishment and growth in grace (WSC 96), like Israel eating the peace offering at God's table.

Closing prayer

Holy Father, we cannot come to you on our own terms, and we have nothing to pay for our sins. Thank you for providing the Lamb. Thank you that Jesus bore your just anger in our place, carried our sins away, and sat down because the work is finished. Give each person here faith to trust him and a heart that turns from sin, and let us draw near to you with confidence. Amen.